

Guide 37 — Shipping, Receiving, and Traffic Clerk

Controlled English working master — version 2.0

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What this job is

Shipping, receiving, and traffic clerks help organizations move goods accurately into, through, and out of a facility. Depending on the employer, related titles may include shipping clerk, receiving clerk, shipping and receiving clerk, traffic clerk, logistics clerk, shipping coordinator, receiving coordinator, materials control associate, order fulfillment specialist, warehouse clerk, or traffic assistant.

In the United States, the closest current official occupation is O*NET **43-5071.00 — Shipping, Receiving, and Inventory Clerks**. The work can include verifying incoming and outgoing shipments, maintaining records, preparing shipping documents, arranging transportation, recording shortages or damage, coordinating with carriers, and updating inventory or warehouse systems.

This guide is for career exploration and preparation. Job titles, physical demands, legal requirements, software, wages, and training pathways vary by employer, sector, and country. Verify current local requirements before paying for training or accepting a job offer.

What you may do

Typical responsibilities can include:

- compare incoming or outgoing goods with purchase orders, invoices, manifests, packing lists, bills of lading, or shipping instructions;
- count, weigh, measure, inspect, label, scan, or record materials and packages;
- document damage, shortages, overages, incorrect items, missing paperwork, or other discrepancies;
- prepare shipping orders, bills of lading, carrier documents, labels, or related records;
- enter shipment information into spreadsheets, ERP systems, warehouse-management systems, inventory systems, EDI tools, or carrier portals;
- coordinate pickups, deliveries, dock schedules, shipment priorities, or carrier communications;
- calculate or verify shipping, storage, handling, or freight-related charges when the role requires it;
- route goods to the correct receiving, storage, staging, production, or shipping area;
- help maintain accurate inventory and shipment records;
- communicate with warehouse, purchasing, production, customer service, suppliers, carriers, drivers, and customers;

- escalate delays, damage, safety issues, suspicious requests, documentation problems, or shipment exceptions; and
- follow employer rules for security, privacy, quality, safety, customs, dangerous goods, and access control where applicable.

Some roles are mostly clerical and system-based. Others involve regular movement through loading docks, warehouses, staging areas, stockrooms, or production facilities.

Work environment

Shipping and receiving work is common in manufacturing, distribution, retail, wholesale, healthcare, e-commerce, transportation, construction supply, food and beverage, government, pharmaceuticals, electronics, automotive, and many other sectors.

Possible conditions include:

- standing and walking;
- bending, reaching, lifting, carrying, or moving items within employer-defined limits;
- loading docks and vehicle traffic;
- forklifts, pallet jacks, conveyors, dock equipment, or other powered equipment;
- noise, temperature changes, or non-climate-controlled work areas;
- deadlines and changing shipment priorities;
- repetitive scanning or data entry;
- personal protective equipment in designated areas; and
- regulated, hazardous, high-value, controlled, or temperature-sensitive goods in some industries.

Never operate powered equipment unless you have the training and authorization required by the employer and local rules. Never bypass safety, hazardous-material, dangerous-goods, customs, quality, food-safety, pharmaceutical, security, lockout/tagout, or PPE controls to move a shipment faster.

Skills that matter

Employers commonly value:

- accuracy and attention to detail;
- basic arithmetic and comfort with quantities, weights, dimensions, dates, and units;
- spreadsheet and data-entry skills;
- barcode, scanner, label, inventory, ERP, or warehouse-system literacy;
- document control and recordkeeping;
- shipping and receiving workflow awareness;
- clear written and verbal communication;
- discrepancy identification and follow-up;
- professional coordination with carriers, suppliers, customers, and internal teams;
- organization and prioritization;

- safe material-handling awareness; and
- calm problem solving when shipments are late, incomplete, damaged, or incorrectly documented.

A particular software product is not universally required. O*NET identifies relevant technologies such as ERP, inventory-management, warehouse-management, EDI, spreadsheets, barcode-labeling, and related logistics systems. Learn the concepts first, then build familiarity with the systems used by the employers you are targeting.

Education and entry pathways

United States

ONET places *Shipping, Receiving, and Inventory Clerks* in **Job Zone 1-2: Very Little to Some Preparation Needed**. Current ONET information indicates that a high school diploma or GED is usually required, although employer requirements vary. On-the-job training can range from a few days to as long as one year depending on the complexity of the role.

A practical entry path can be:

1. Build basic spreadsheet, business communication, shipping, receiving, inventory, and documentation skills.
2. Learn the concepts behind purchase orders, packing lists, manifests, bills of lading, shipment status, carrier tracking, discrepancies, and inventory updates.
3. Practice with fictional shipping records, labels, receiving logs, and discrepancy reports.
4. Apply for shipping clerk, receiving clerk, shipping/receiving clerk, warehouse clerk, order fulfillment, logistics-support, or traffic-assistant roles.
5. Use paid onboarding and cross-training to learn the employer's actual carrier portals, ERP/WMS tools, safety rules, documentation standards, and escalation process.
6. Progress toward shipping coordinator, receiving coordinator, traffic coordinator, logistics coordinator, inventory-control, materials-control, or supervisory roles as experience grows.

Canada

Government of Canada Job Bank maps closely comparable work to **Shippers and receivers, NOC 14400**. Current national requirements state that completion of secondary school is usually required. Related clerical or warehouse experience may be required, and some jobs may require a forklift certificate or driver's licence.

Job Bank currently records this occupation as not regulated nationally. Employers can still require local safety training, equipment authorization, language ability, sector-specific credentials, software skills, or experience.

Colombia

SENA currently provides several relevant logistics pathways through Betowa. Examples include:

- **Integración de Operaciones Logísticas** — technical training covering logistics information, storage, receiving, dispatch, merchandise handling, workplace safety, and related tools;
- **Administración y Control de Inventarios** — complementary training covering inventory concepts, control models, costs, and policies; and
- **Almacenamiento, Movilización y Alistamiento de Mercancías** — complementary training focused on storage, movement, and preparation of goods.

Availability, location, delivery mode, and enrollment windows can change. Verify the live Betowa listing before planning around a specific cohort.

Colombian job seekers can also use the Ministry of Labour's **Sistema Nacional de Cualificaciones** to explore qualification pathways and recognition of prior learning, and **OCUPACOL** to explore occupational profiles and related titles.

Useful Colombian search terms can include *auxiliar de almacén*, *auxiliar logístico*, *recibo y despacho*, *despachos*, *inventarios*, *bodega*, *alistamiento*, *operaciones logísticas*, and *shipping/receiving*.

Latin America and the Caribbean

Training systems vary by country. OIT/Cinterfor can help learners locate public and social-partner vocational-training institutions across Latin America and the Caribbean. Use it as a locator rather than assuming there is one regional credential standard.

Verify the current national institution, eligibility, cost, practical component, funding, recognition, and local employer relevance before paying for private training.

Free-first learning strategy

Do not assume you need an expensive private logistics certificate before applying. A safer sequence is:

1. Read current job postings in your target area and list the recurring requirements.
2. Use public, employer-provided, or low-cost training first.
3. Build spreadsheet, shipping, receiving, inventory, label/scanner, ERP/WMS, and documentation literacy.
4. Ask employers about paid onboarding, cross-training, equipment training, tuition assistance, reimbursement, trainee roles, or internal promotion.
5. Consider paid training only after verifying total cost, refund rules, employer recognition, and whether the credential appears in real job postings.

Transferable experience in warehousing, retail stockrooms, purchasing support, inventory, manufacturing, logistics, customer order support, transportation, administration, or production can be valuable.

Apprenticeship and work-based learning

In the United States, O*NET links this occupation family to Apprenticeship.gov resources. Registered Apprenticeship programs are employer-driven pathways that can combine paid work, mentorship, structured instruction, progressive wage increases, and a nationally recognized credential.

Use Apprenticeship.gov to search current openings. The existence of a related occupation does not mean a current apprenticeship is available in your area.

Outside the United States, look for broader forms of work-based learning such as:

- paid trainee roles;
- employer apprenticeships;
- internships or work-study programs;
- dual-training models;
- public technical programs with practical stages;
- employer cross-training; and
- internal promotion from warehouse, inventory, receiving, shipping, or fulfillment roles.

Funding, scholarships, and employer support

United States

CareerOneStop, sponsored by the U.S. Department of Labor, provides tools for training, scholarships, internships, certifications, and local workforce assistance. Its **WIOA-Eligible Training Program Finder** can help eligible job seekers identify approved programs.

WIOA funding is not automatic. Eligibility, covered programs, local rules, and available funding vary by workforce area and individual circumstances.

Canada

Eligible post-secondary learners may qualify for **Canada Student Grants and Loans** through federal, provincial, or territorial systems. Grants generally do not need to be repaid; loans do.

Federal student-aid rules changed on August 1, 2026 for certain private for-profit schools, with transition rules for some continuing students. Verify current eligibility for your school and program before enrolling. Short private warehouse or logistics courses are not automatically eligible for student aid.

Colombia and Latin America

Check public vocational systems before paying private providers. In Colombia, start with SENA and the national qualifications system. Elsewhere in Latin America, use OIT/Cinterfor to identify the relevant public vocational institution and then verify current enrollment and funding rules on that institution's official site.

Employer support

Ask about:

- paid onboarding;
- shipping/receiving-system training;
- ERP, WMS, EDI, scanner, or carrier-portal training;
- safety and material-handling training;
- forklift or other equipment training where the role requires it and the employer provides or recognizes appropriate training;
- cross-training in inventory, warehouse, purchasing, production, logistics, or customer service;
- tuition assistance;
- certification reimbursement;
- apprenticeships or trainee programs; and
- internal promotion pathways.

Get reimbursement conditions in writing before spending money. Some programs require continued employment or repayment if you leave within a specified period.

Income and job outlook

United States — official occupational data

O*NET currently reports Bureau of Labor Statistics data for **Shipping, Receiving, and Inventory Clerks**:

- **Median hourly wage (2025): \$21.76**
- **Median annual wage (2025): \$45,260**
- **Employment (2024): approximately 862,200**
- **Projected employment (2034): approximately 795,800**
- **Projected employment change, 2024–2034: -8%**
- **Projected annual openings, 2024–2034: approximately 69,300**

These are national occupational statistics. They are not a promised starting wage and can differ substantially by location, industry, shift, union status, physical demands, experience, employer, and responsibility level.

United States — current non-government estimates

Current private-market salary sites use different methodologies and should be treated as supplementary only.

As of July 2026:

- Indeed reported an average U.S. base wage of about **\$19.39 per hour** for *Shipping and Receiving Clerk*, updated July 20, 2026.

- Salary.com reported an average of about 44,499 *per year* *for Shipping and Receiving Clerk* as of July 1, 2026, with a stated range of **40,384–\$49,968**.

These are **non-government market estimates**, not official occupational medians and not guaranteed earnings.

Canada — official national data

Government of Canada Job Bank currently reports the following national wages for **Shippers and receivers, NOC 14400**:

- low: **CAD \$17.00 per hour**
- median: **CAD \$22.50 per hour**
- high: **CAD \$31.00 per hour**

The national wage table was updated November 19, 2025 using 2023–2024 Labour Force Survey data. Local wages and prospects vary by province and region.

A practical 10-week starter plan

Weeks 1–2: Read 15–20 current local job postings. Record common titles, shifts, physical requirements, software, equipment, documentation, education, and experience requirements.

Weeks 3–4: Strengthen spreadsheet, data-entry, and recordkeeping skills. Practice item numbers, quantities, addresses, dates, shipment references, carrier details, and simple discrepancy logs.

Weeks 5–6: Learn core shipping and receiving concepts: purchase orders, packing lists, manifests, bills of lading, freight terms at a basic level, carrier tracking, receiving inspection, shortages, damage, overages, labeling, staging, and inventory updates.

Weeks 7–8: Build a small practice exercise using fictional data. Receive a sample shipment, identify a discrepancy, record it, prepare a receiving note, create a simple shipping record, and write a short professional status update.

Weeks 9–10: Verify public training, funding, employer support, work-based-learning options, reimbursement rules, and the actual requirements of the jobs you plan to pursue. Update your resume using truthful examples of accuracy, logistics, order handling, inventory, shipping, receiving, customer service, documentation, or problem solving.

Building experience without already having the title

Transferable experience can come from:

- warehouse operations;
- inventory or stockroom work;
- retail receiving;
- order fulfillment;
- purchasing or procurement support;

- manufacturing or production support;
- logistics or transportation support;
- maintenance parts rooms;
- healthcare supply rooms;
- customer-service work involving orders, deliveries, or returns;
- office or asset-control work; and
- e-commerce fulfillment.

When describing experience, show what you actually did. Useful evidence includes:

- verifying counts or shipment contents;
- maintaining accurate records;
- documenting shortages or damage;
- tracking orders or deliveries;
- resolving discrepancies;
- preparing labels or shipping paperwork;
- coordinating with carriers, suppliers, or customers;
- reducing data-entry errors;
- improving handoffs; and
- following safety, security, quality, or privacy procedures.

Do not claim ERP, WMS, EDI, forklift, dangerous-goods, customs, or advanced logistics expertise if you have only studied the concepts.

Advancement

Possible next steps include:

- senior shipping or receiving clerk;
- shipping coordinator;
- receiving coordinator;
- traffic coordinator;
- logistics coordinator;
- inventory control specialist;
- materials coordinator;
- warehouse coordinator;
- order fulfillment lead;
- transportation coordinator;
- warehouse supervisor; or
- supply-chain support roles.

Advanced positions may require stronger ERP/WMS knowledge, carrier-management experience, analytics, supervisory experience, sector-specific compliance knowledge, formal logistics education, or deeper transportation and materials-management experience.

Before paying for a degree or certificate, compare several current job postings for the exact role you want and determine whether the credential is actually requested.

Using AI responsibly in this work

AI tools may help you:

- draft a neutral shipment-status message;
- create practice interview questions;
- summarize non-sensitive training notes;
- explain general logistics concepts;
- create fictional spreadsheet exercises; or
- brainstorm questions to ask during onboarding.

AI should not replace the employer's shipping, receiving, customs, dangerous-goods, carrier, quality, inventory, security, or safety procedures.

Do not paste confidential manifests, customer names or addresses, supplier data, tracking numbers, shipment values, proprietary inventory information, credentials, security details, customs documents, regulated information, or other protected business information into a public AI service unless your employer has explicitly approved that use and the data handling is authorized.

Verify AI-generated quantities, weights, dimensions, addresses, routing information, shipping classifications, rates, customs information, dates, formulas, recommendations, and citations before operational use. A plausible-looking error can create shipment delays, compliance problems, financial loss, inventory errors, or safety risks.

Cybersecurity and privacy basics

Shipping and receiving systems can contain commercially sensitive and personally identifiable information. Follow your employer's rules for:

- account access and multifactor authentication;
- passwords and credential sharing;
- phishing and suspicious attachments;
- approved scanners, mobile devices, and carrier portals;
- file sharing and removable media;
- customer names and addresses;
- supplier and carrier information;
- shipment values and inventory details;
- facility and dock information;
- incident reporting; and
- use of personal devices or external AI tools.

Be especially cautious with unusual requests to change delivery addresses, carrier instructions, payment details, pickup times, shipment priorities, or account credentials. Verify sensitive changes through the employer's approved process before acting.

Avoid scams and weak training offers

Be cautious when a school, recruiter, or training seller:

- guarantees a job or specific salary;
- pressures you to pay immediately;
- claims one private certificate is legally required when official sources do not support that claim;
- will not disclose total cost, refund rules, or financing terms;
- cannot explain which employers recognize the credential;
- asks you to pay for a job offer, background check, shipping equipment, or training through gift cards, cryptocurrency, or an unusual payment method; or
- asks for sensitive identity or banking information before you have verified the organization.

Verify employers and training providers independently and use official websites whenever possible.

When to pause before spending money

Pause or delay enrollment when:

- local job postings do not require the credential you are considering;
- the provider will not give total costs and refund terms in writing;
- public or employer-paid training may cover the same skill;
- you have not confirmed whether employers in your area recognize the program;
- the schedule or physical demands do not fit your circumstances; or
- the financing terms create debt you cannot comfortably repay.

Current sources

Official/public sources:

- U.S. Department of Labor O*NET OnLine — Shipping, Receiving, and Inventory Clerks: <https://www.onetonline.org/link/summary/43-5071.00>
- O*NET Local Trends: <https://www.onetonline.org/link/localtrends/43-5071.00>
- Apprenticeship.gov — Career Seekers: <https://www.apprenticeship.gov/career-seekers>
- CareerOneStop — Find Training: <https://www.careeronestop.org/FindTraining/find-training.aspx>
- CareerOneStop — WIOA-Eligible Training Program Finder: <https://www.careeronestop.org/LocalHelp/EmploymentAndTraining/find-WIOA-training-programs.aspx>

- Government of Canada Job Bank — Shippers and receivers:
<https://www.jobbank.gc.ca/marketreport/summary-occupation/15242/ca>
- Government of Canada Job Bank — Requirements:
<https://www.jobbank.gc.ca/marketreport/requirements/15242/ca>
- Government of Canada Job Bank — Wages:
<https://www.jobbank.gc.ca/marketreport/wages-occupation/15242/ca>
- Canada Student Grants and Loans:
<https://www.canada.ca/en/services/benefits/education/student-aid/grants-loans.html>
- SENA Betowa — Integración de Operaciones Logísticas:
<https://betowa.sena.edu.co/oferta/integracion-de-operaciones-logisticas?programId=96327>
- SENA Betowa — Administración y Control de Inventarios:
<https://betowa.sena.edu.co/oferta/administracion-y-control-de-inventarios?modality=V&offertype=company>
- SENA Betowa — Almacenamiento, Movilización y Alistamiento de Mercancías:
<https://betowa.sena.edu.co/oferta/almacenamiento-movilizacion-y-alistamiento-de-mercancias?modality=P&offertype=company&programId=172615>
- Colombia Ministerio del Trabajo — Sistema Nacional de Cualificaciones:
<https://cualificaciones.mintrabajo.gov.co/>
- Colombia Ministerio del Trabajo — OCUPACOL: <https://ocupacol.mintrabajo.gov.co/>
- OIT/Cinterfor institutions locator: <https://www.oitcinterfor.org/statsfp/instituciones>

Supplementary non-government salary sources:

- Indeed — Shipping and Receiving Clerk salaries:
<https://www.indeed.com/career/shipping-and-receiving-clerk/salaries>
- Salary.com — Shipping and Receiving Clerk salary:
<https://www.salary.com/research/salary/recruiting/shipping-and-receiving-clerk-salary>

Source and review note

This guide uses current-source research recorded on August 12, 2026. Wages, training availability, program rules, software expectations, safety requirements, and local hiring conditions can change. Recheck official sources and current job postings before acting.

This controlled revision was produced with AI assistance and auditable source review. It does **not** claim independent human certification, professional accreditation, certified translation, legal review, safety certification, financial advice, or guaranteed employment outcomes.